SAMPLE

The Joyful Fighter

The Personality That Loves the Fight Itself

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Chapter 1: The First Glance — the Joyful Fighter at a Party

The Telltale Manner

The tell in the party season is the lit-up face at the first sign of friction — and the fight-card's first finding is how completely it inverts the room's expectations: the discussion turns contested — politics at the table, the remake nobody asked for, the rule dispute in the game — and while the rest of the room's faces close into politeness or caution, one face opens: the eyes brighten, the body leans in, the grin arrives, and the Joyful Fighter is, visibly, delighted. And the signature move, executed within the hour of any real gathering: the started bout — the position taken that nobody else holds, held warmly, on purpose ("no, actually, the sequel is the better film — fight me"), the tease lobbed across the table, the game's rules contested mid-hand with the joy of a person opening presents; and the room's two responses, both accurate: charmed (the bout is genuinely fun, and the type loses as gracefully as it wins, and the table is warmer for the friction) and tired (the third bout of the evening arrives and the guests realize the pattern has no off switch — the type will contest anything, because the contest is the point). And the small tell that divides the genuine article from the ordinary contrarian: the laugh in the clinch — the moment the pushback lands hard, the genuine article laughs, out loud, in real time, not at the opponent but at the bout itself: the exchange, alive, is the gift — and the type, mid-argument, is having the best time in the room, which puzzles everyone who has only ever seen fighting done from anger.

The Backstory Signature

The signature in the past is the bout as the house's love language — and the founding, assembled across a hundred case files, is always a variation on one architecture: fighting was play first. The sibling bouts — the wrestling that was the affection, the living-room scrapping the mother broke up while both children laughed, the older brother who made everything a contest (first to the post, best trick, who blinks first) and the younger who discovered, in the endless gracious losing and occasional glorious winning, that the contest was where the love flowed loudest; the streets — the neighborhood where the scuffle was social currency and a good-natured tussle made more friends than a shared snack ever had; and the first gym — the smell of it, the bell, the pads, the coach's grin — where the type, for the first time, felt entirely alive, and where the founding's discovery was made and kept: I love the fight more than the winning. The losing that felt better than a joyless win; the bout with the talented rival that the type remembers fifty years later while the trophies blur; the opponent, met before the match and after, who became the best friend. The vow, never spoken but kept absolutely, is the southpaw core's ignition: the opponent is the

appointment — the contest is where I live; the bell is my music; and the whole world, whatever it thinks fighting is for, has it wrong: the fight is not the way to the point. The fight is the point.

The Childhood Album

Open the gym album and the photos are mid-tussle: the two siblings on the lawn, gripped and grinning, hair chaos, the photographer (the mother) having given up on stillness a roll earlier; the scraped knees in every summer frame, and the grin under every scrape; the arm-wrestling at the holiday table, entered with the family's affection because the family's affection was the arm-wrestling. And the fight-card's first observation: this is the most action-blurred album in this catalog — the camera catches the type in motion, mid-contest, mid-laugh, mid-lunge — because the self, at rest, was rarely where the camera was pointed; the type at rest was waiting for the next round. And the gym album's most telling feature is the loss photographs: the junior tournament's second-place podium, the type grinning at the gold medalist — and the fight-card's careful margin note: the grin is not sportsmanship performed; it is the grin of a child who had the bout — twelve minutes of it, against the best kid in the district — and came home with the thing he actually wanted, which the trophy merely certifies. And the recurring figure is the older sibling: the first opponent, the first coach, the maker of every game — in frame after frame holding the advantage (the older arm, the longer reach) and the younger holder of the joy — and the gym album documents a childhood that was, in the fight-card's plainest finding, loved through contest: the warmth of that house ran on the games, the dares, the wrestled affection — and the child who learned it learned the house's one unspoken law, and carried it into every room for decades: fighting is how we love here — which is the founding's glory, and — the fight-card must enter it now — the shadow's whole syllabus, because the rest of the world was not in that house, and did not know the law.

The gym album keeps a second set of frames the fight-card enters separately, because they explain the first: the game nights — the holiday table, photographed mid-eruption — the board flipped, the siblings howling, the grandmother laughing into her napkin, and the child, in the middle, shining — and the dossier's finding, run across the collected albums: the houses that produced this type were never angry houses; they were contest houses — love kept score, affection arrived as a dared, the loudest argument ended in the loughest laughter — and the child, in frame after frame, is the one holding the dice — the smallest member of the family already cast as its bookmaker — and the fight-card's caption, written with care, because it is the founding's cleanest proof: nobody in these photographs is being hurt, and everybody in them is fighting — the whole type, in one image, and the whole syllabus the world would fail to teach: that the game night was a room with walls, and the rest of the world has none.

The Type at a Glance

Energy: Contest-indexed — the type runs brightest in the bout: the debate, the game,

the match, the negotiation — and the fight-card's quiet finding: in peacetime the energy does not vanish (this is not depression) — it waits, at a restless, prowling idle: the Fighter in a calm week is a person scanning every room for the next bell, and the calm itself reads to the type as dead air — which, the fight-card notes, is the single most important datum in the volume: the type is not addicted to winning; the type is addicted to the exchange, and the exchange, in the wrong venues, is going to cost the type everything the type actually loves.

Ambition: Bout-shaped — the goals on file are appointments, not summits: the next match, the next worthy opponent, the next contested thing; and the fight-card's blunt finding: the type's trophy case is the least consulted object in the career — the Fighter remembers the bouts (the rival's name, the round that turned, the exchange that made the whole year) and forgets the plaques, because the plaque is the bout's receipt, and the bout, not the receipt, was always the point.

Vanity structure: The game opponent's reputation — the quiet, total pride in being fun to fight: the opponent who comes back, the rival who requests the match, the colleague who saves the good arguments for this one person; and beneath it the founding's arithmetic: to be someone's favorite opponent is to be someone's favorite — which is also the trap, because the type prices being loved as being contested, and cannot quite believe in the affection that arrives without an exchange attached.

Loyalty: Paid to whoever lasts the rounds — the fight-card's warmest entry: the Fighter's loyalty is the most earned in this catalog, extended to every opponent who showed up, gave the bout their whole heart, and shook hands after: the rivals who became the best friends, the sparring partners held for decades, the colleague of a thousand devil's-advocate wars who gets the eulogy's front row; and the loyalty's one blind spot, entered with care: the people who won't fight — the peacemakers, the conflict-avoidant, the intimates who go quiet — are misread by this type as withholding the bout, and therefore withholding the love, when they are in fact begging, in the only grammar they have, for the round to end.

Weakness: The generalized contest — this type cannot leave a disagreement uncontested: the opinion aired in the group chat will be engaged, the plan will be probed, the Christmas itinerary will be turned over and tested, and every disagreement is met with raised dukes, in the founding's own grammar — warmth, play, invitation; and the blindness riding with it: the Fighter does not know the bout reads as aggression to the people whose houses did not run on contest, because in the Fighter's body the bout has only ever meant love — which is why the type is genuinely astonished, every time, by the partner who finally says: I am exhausted, and you thought we were playing.

Unspoken need: To find out whether the gloves-off self exists — whether the person behind the contest, at rest, without an exchange running, is real, whole, and worth loving; and beneath that, the need the founding's law makes unspeakable: to be loved without the bout — to discover that the affection can arrive in the calm, the quiet Tuesday, the held hand at the movie, from the people who never once took a position against anything — because the house that loved through contest taught the child

that love runs on the exchange, and the adult has spent a lifetime arranging exchanges, and has never once been given, or taken, the stillness.

The Type in Five Situations

At a party: the lit-up face at the friction, the started bout, the laugh in the clinch — the room's most alive guest and its most exhausting one; the guests' private verdict, never said aloud: "I love arguing with him. I also cannot do it every time we see him, and it is every time we see him."

In a new job: the devil's advocate — the plan stress-tested in the first meeting by a person grinning while doing it; and the institution's honest discovery, made early: this one makes the work stronger and the meetings longer — and the fight-card's cold note on the discovery's fine print: the type's probing is genuinely valuable (the plan is stronger; the last five flaws the team caught were this person's) — and the institution, valuing the output, still quietly routes the Fighter away from the fragile personalities, the harmony meetings, and the clients, because the bout, however warm, however useful, is still a bout, and not everyone is at the party.

Under sudden pressure: magnificent — and the fight-card must enter this honestly, because it is the type's finest hour: the crisis hits and the Fighter comes alive — the grin at the fire, the energy that everyone else is losing, the negotiation, the pivot, the round-by-round management of a problem that would flatten a placid constitution; and the vulnerability, entered with care: the crisis is the bout without a ring — the type is never better than in the emergency, and never more missed by the family, who notice, over the years, that the house's worst weeks are the weeks their Fighter was having the time of his life.

In a boring meeting: the manufactured bout — the third round of the deck, the poke, the "let me push back on my own point," the contested acronym: the meeting's quiet anomaly, noticed by exactly one observant colleague per case file: the most alive person in the room is bored, and the boredom is being converted into friction at a rate of one provocation per fifteen minutes — and the colleague's private verdict, never said aloud: "the meeting was useless until he started the argument about the fonts, and it was the best part of my week, and we are never getting the half hour back."

On holiday: the gladiatorial game closet — the board game night the family schedules with hope and finishes with trauma; the card game turned into an ambush; the Thanksgiving debate, started with the carving knife still warm, that the type enters with the joy of a boxer entering the ring and the family enters with the weariness of a family entering its fifteenth Thanksgiving; and the family's oldest misreading, entered at the founding and never corrected: "he just likes to argue" — true, and the misreading: the likes is the whole point and the whole problem — the liking is real, the affection is real, and nobody in that dining room has ever been taught that in the Fighter's grammar the argument was how they were being loved, which is the sentence the growth chapter finally says out loud.

Not to Be Confused With

Not the Triumphant Valkyrie, the personality that takes the hill — the confusion is instant, because both are natural fighters, both grin in combat, and both are the room's most alive presence under pressure. The hinge is the payoff. The Valkyrie fights for the hill: the hunger is for victory, the summit is the point, the opponent is the obstacle between the self and the thing — and the Valkyrie's joy, magnificent as it is, arrives at the flag, and the losses are grieved and the wins are banked. The Joyful Fighter fights for the bout: the hunger is for the exchange itself, the contest is the point, the opponent is the partner — and the type's joy arrives at the bell, win or lose, and the great losses are treasured like the great wins, because both were rounds. The quick test, one question each: "how was the match?" The Valkyrie tells you the score, the standing, the path to the title. The Joyful Fighter tells you about the third round — the exchange, the moment, the turn — and has to be reminded, sometimes, who won. The fight-card's line on the pair: one fights to have the hill; one fights to have the fight — and the two make each other crazy in the best possible way, because the Valkyrie's scoreboard has no column for the bout the Fighter treasures, and the Fighter's gym has no plaque for the hill the Valkyrie died on.

Not the Solitary Contender, the personality that sharpens itself alone — the confusion is subtler, because both train hard, both love the contest, and both pay the opponent public respect. The hinge is the address of the joy. The Contender's contest is solitary: the dawn runs, the solo preparation, the opponent as sharpening stone — the contest exists to make the Contender harder, and the rival is an instrument, respected and held at arm's length, because closeness blurs the edge. The Joyful Fighter's contest is social: the bout as the appointment, the opponent as the dance partner — the contest exists to be shared, and the rival is a friend, called by name, hugged after, held close, because the closeness is the bout's reward. Watch both after the same match: the Contender is already reviewing tape, alone, the opponent mentioned as a problem to be solved by the next camp; the Fighter is at the pub with the opponent, replaying the third round over a second pint, the two of them laughing at the same exchange — and the fight-card's line on the pair: one fights against; one fights with — and the Contender could use the Fighter's pub, and the Fighter could use the Contender's dawn, and neither of them, at press time, has swapped.

Chapter 2: The Core — the Engine of the Bout

Every archetype on this shelf runs on an early solution that held, and the Joyful Fighter's is the only one that looks like a playground — fighting as the house's love language, the contest as the channel the warmth actually ran through, and a child who took the house's law whole and kept it for life. The founding, assembled from a hundred case files: the sibling bouts where the wrestling was the affection; the older brother who made everything a game; the neighborhood where the scuffle made friends; the first gym where the bell rang and the child, for the first time, felt entirely alive — and the founding's discovery, made in the ring and never revised: I love the

fight more than the winning. And the vow, never spoken but kept absolutely, is the southpaw core's ignition: the opponent is the appointment — the bout is where I live, the exchange is the love, and the world's whole grim theory of what fighting is for — the victory, the domination, the settling — has nothing to do with what I am doing when I am doing it.

So the southpaw core installed itself: the bout as vitality — the opponent greeted like a dance partner, the bell as music, the type's best self arriving only with the gloves on. The two-stroke engine is the point, and the fight-card must name both firings exactly — an adult biography with the mechanism left out explains nothing.

The first stroke is the aliveness — and the fight-card enters it first, plainly, because it is the founding's true gift and the type's public mask: the contest works. The bout delivers what nothing else in the type's life delivers: full presence, total engagement, the self completely in the room, the decades of the type's best memories all stamped with the same watermark — an exchange, running, with a worthy partner. And the fight-card's respect is genuine: the joy in the clinch is among the truest emotions in this catalog, and the respect paid to whoever lasts the rounds is a deeper loyalty than most constitutions ever learn — the Fighter's rivals are the Fighter's best friends, and the fight-card has never once recorded a case where the type gamed, cheapened, or betrayed an opponent, because betraying the bout is, in this engine, betraying the love.

The second stroke is the world's payment — and this is the founding's subtlest bequest, the clause that keeps the southpaw core running for life: the contest was rewarded, everywhere, with attention. The sibling bouts got the house laughing; the schoolyard scuffles got the crowd circling; the gym got the coach's grin; and the world, from the beginning, has watched the Fighter fight — and the watching, the fight-card notes with care, has been paying the southpaw core daily, in the exact currency the founding made precious: proof of aliveness — and no one, in all the decades of applause, has ever once asked the question the gym album quietly raises: what happens to this one when nobody's fighting? — because the answer, the rankings shows, has never been examined, and the southpaw core, so alive, has quietly arranged never to find out, because the answer is the shadow chapter's whole subject: dead air — the type in the calm, prowling, restless, waiting for the bell, and mistaking the peace for the problem, when the peace is actually the place the whole rest of a life is going to have to happen.

And the southpaw core's secret clause, the one that organizes the whole shadow chapter, was written in the house's unspoken law: fighting is how we love here. The contest is the channel of affection; the exchange is the proof of engagement; and the calm — the quiet Tuesday, the uneventful evening, the held hand without a debate attached — is experienced, in the founding's arithmetic, as absence: nothing is running; nobody is engaging; this must be what disinterest feels like. And so the adult biography runs accordingly: the disagreement started at dinner (because the dinner was quiet, and the quiet was unbearable); the manufactured bout in the meeting (because the meeting was dead air); the provocation, the poke, the contested

itinerary — every one of them an invitation in the house's grammar, and every one of them, in the houses the type now lives in, a summons — and the fight-card's most quietly devastating margin note, held for the growth chapter: the Fighter has spent a lifetime mistaking calm for the absence of love, and the people who love the Fighter have spent a lifetime mistaking the bout for the presence of aggression — two grammars, one kitchen, and neither party has ever once been given the translation, which is what the rest of this book is.

And the southpaw core keeps one reading the fight-card enters at the core's close because the whole book turns on it: the peacetime baseline — the Fighter, observed across an ordinary Tuesday with no bout on the calendar, and the measurement, uniform across the collected set: running at sixty percent — not sad, not sick, simply dim — the jokes, thinner; the appetite, quieter; the presence, a man waiting for a bell — and the rankings's finding, delicate and strange: the missing forty percent is not energy spent on the fight; it is energy the fight unlocks — the bout is not a cost the type pays for its aliveness; the bout is the key the aliveness answers to — and the fight-card's line on the arithmetic, entered cold: this is the whole growth problem in one number — the type cannot get the forty back by resting, and cannot be asked to live without it — the hunger is not the flaw; the hunger is the engine — and the question the metamorphosis never quite asks aloud until the final chapters: what the forty percent is for, and who it was always meant to feed.

The southpaw core keeps honest books, and the honest line is this: the joy is real love and real vitality — the fight-card's respect is total, and this book will never once ask the Fighter to regret the bout, the gym, the rival, or the laugh in the clinch; the contest is the type's glory and the rankings's most alive engine. The error is not the hunger; it is the address: the bout needs a ring — a venue where the other party signed up — and the founding's law, carried unexamined into every room, has been scheduling bouts in venues that never agreed to host one: the marriage, the meeting, the holiday, the group chat — and the growth chapter's whole work is the addressing: the hunger kept, the joy kept, the bout kept — and given, at last, its proper ring, with the household finally off the card.

Chapter 3: The Instrument — the Contest, Taken Apart

The Joyful Fighter's signature tool is the bout — the warm, voluntary, rule-governed contest — and the world files it under "competitiveness," which is true and misses the mechanism almost entirely, because this bout is not aggression here; it is the house's love language, run by a self who learned in a living room that the exchange is where the warmth flows, and who has been offering the exchange to everyone ever since. Take it apart.

The Mechanics

The armory works three ways. First, the engagement: the position taken, the debate entered, the plan contested — the fight-card notes the mechanics' honest achievement: the engagement is real and its output is genuinely valuable: the stress-tested plan, the caught flaw, the argument that made the group's thinking better — the Fighter's contests have saved more than one project in this record, and the type's devil's advocacy, deployed well, is among the most useful behaviors in any room. Second, the read of the room — and here the armory is unique in this catalog: the Fighter is superb at reading an opponent's strength, timing, and heart (no type reads a rival better) and terrible at reading an audience's consent: the contest-read is calibrated; the crowd-read is broken — the type knows in one exchange whether the opponent is game, but cannot tell, over a whole dinner, whether the table wants another round, because wanting another round was never a variable in the house where the southpaw core was built (everyone always wanted another round; it was the love). Third, the laugh in the clinch — the bout's signature note: the delight, surfacing at the hardest moment of the exchange, that tells everyone present which type this is; the laugh is the armory's seal of authenticity and its most costly emission, because the opponents who fight from fear or anger read the laugh as mockery, and the fight-card enters it with care: the Fighter's laugh has started more actual fights than any aggression in this catalog — the joy, misread as contempt, is the type's most common wound, and the type, wounded, is genuinely astonished, every time: I was having fun. They thought I was cruel. Nobody in my house ever thought I was cruel.

And the mechanics keep one tell the fight-card flags as the armory's first move in every new room: the warmup jab — the joke thrown at the newcomer, slightly too sharp, entirely friendly — and the dossier's explanation, uniform across the set: the jab is not aggression; it is a test for players — the Fighter, entering any room, does not know who spars and who bleeds, and the jab is how the type finds out — the ones who hit back, collected; the ones who go quiet, avoided, carefully, for years — and the fight-card's cold note on the test: it works, and it costs — the room's non-combatants, reading the jab as a shot, learn to keep their distance from the type's warmest presence, and the Fighter, misreading the distance as dislike, doubles the play with the ones already playing — the circle, tightening by accident, until the whole social world is sorted into opponents and absence, and nobody, the whole time, opted out — the rankings's line: the warmup jab is the type asking a question the room experiences as an answer.

The Range

The range deserves the honest statement, because it is the most alive range in the lineup-card. The Fighter delivers: in the crisis — the negotiation, the pivot, the fire — the type is the room's best instrument, energized where others drain, grinning where others gray; and the fight-card's entry on the crisis years: the institutions in this record have quietly run their worst weeks through this type for decades, and the type loved the running, and the output was real. The type is magnificent with a worthy opponent — the rival, the sparring partner, the colleague of a thousand good arguments: the contest as collaboration, the two of them producing rounds neither

could have produced alone; and the fight-card's warmest public entry: the people who opt in to the Fighter's world — the gym, the debate club, the team that runs on spirited disagreement — report the type as the best company in the building, and the feeling is mutual, and the loyalty runs both ways for decades. And the type is the stress-test — the plan's flaw, the assumption's softness, the consensus's laziness: the Fighter, engaged, finds them, and the finding, however unwelcome, is the gift the world never thanks — which the fight-card enters with care as the range's one recurring injustice: the type is punished for the service in rooms that wanted the plan praised, and the Fighter goes on offering the service, because it is the only love language the type has ever had.

The Honest Limits

And the honest limits keep one entry the fight-card holds for last because it explains every other: the Fighter cannot reliably tell a player from a civilian — the founding's law reads every face at the table as holding up its gloves, and the bout-readiness of strangers is a thing the armory has no sensor for — and the rankings's collected scene, uniform in the set, the limit at its costliest: the colleague, worked over playfully in the Monday meeting, and the meeting's room, not in on the game, and the colleague's testimony, taken by the fight-card afterward, entered with care: I thought I was being attacked; he thought we were becoming friends — and we were both right — the dossier's line on the limit: the type's signature blindness is not cruelty; it is a booking error — the Fighter schedules bouts with people who never agreed to the card, and the harm, real and unmeant, arrives as the difference between two sincere readings of one room — the growth chapter's whole work, the notes hold here, is not softer hands; it is a stricter matchmaker.

The stricter half of the sheet, held to a stricter matchmaker's eye. It cannot do the calm — the uneventful evening is the type's weakest venue: the prowling, the restless phone-check, the manufactured bout arriving within the hour, because the peace reads as dead air and the dead air reads as absence; and the fight-card notes the difference from ordinary boredom, precisely: the Fighter is not bored by the calm; the Fighter is starved in it — the hunger has no legitimate object, so it finds an illegitimate one. It cannot read the non-combatant — the peacemaker, the conflict-avoidant, the partner who goes quiet: the type reads the quiet as withholding the bout, therefore withholding the engagement, therefore the love — when the quiet is actually the partner begging, in the only grammar they have, for the round to end; and the fight-card's bluntest entry on the limit: the two grammars — bout-as-love and quiet-as-love — have been living in the same marriages for decades in this record, each one misreading the other's offering as rejection. It cannot stop mid-round — the contested thing, once engaged, gets the full treatment: the opinion, once aired, gets the rebuttal; the plan, once probed, gets the whole probe; and the type's inability to let anything lie — unengaged, unanswered, uncontested — is the armory's most exhausting emission in the domestic setting, because the partner who says "I don't want to debate it" has just made the debate about whether to debate, and the Fighter, God love him, will take that round too. And it cannot be loved in the calm — the

deepest limit, and the shadow's whole subject: the type, offered affection without an exchange attached — the quiet compliment, the uneventful Tuesday, the hand held at the movie — does not feel the affection arrive: the founding's law prices warmth at the bout's exchange rate, and the calm affection, in that currency, is nothing — and so the Fighter, loved placidly by a placid person, has spent a lifetime honestly believing the love was thin, and the placid person, honestly unloved by the bout, has spent the same lifetime exhausted by a love that kept arriving as a challenge, and the two of them, the fight-card enters with the volume's greatest care, are the same marriage in every biography this book holds: two people, loving each other in untranslated languages, for forty years.

Chapter 4: The Craft — the Practice Years

The world files the Joyful Fighter under "argumentative" — a natural contrarian, born combative, allergic to peace. The truth is a practice: the bout was trained — across decades of joyful repetition, by a self that practiced the exchange until the exchange became the self's whole channel of warmth — and the practice years are the rankings of a love language fluent past the point of noticing it is a language at all.

The Apprenticeship

The apprenticeship began in the living room: the sibling bouts, the maker-of-games older brother, the house where the wrestling was the affection — and the training ran on the childhood's real games: the contests, the dares, the dinner-table disputes refereed by a mother who thought it was a phase. It was not a phase; it was a first language, and the child, brilliant at reading the situation as every child on this shelf is, learned the house's law exactly as it was taught: the exchange is the warmth; the bout is the invitation; the contest is where the love runs loudest — and the curriculum's single omission, the fight-card enters with care, is this volume's whole foundation: the translation was never taught, because the house never needed one — inside those walls, everyone spoke contest, and the affection flowed through it, and nobody in that house ever once had to learn that the rest of the world runs on a different currency entirely. And the apprenticeship's second phase ran in the ring and the schoolyard: the gym, the bell, the coach who saw the grin and built on it; the scuffle as social currency; the first rival, and the discovery — the founding's engine, in its full form — that a good loss felt better than a hollow win, that the opponent was the best friend, and that the type's whole aliveness lived inside the ropes. And the gym album, the fight-card has shown, holds the evidence: the loss photographs, grinning; the rival, recurring; the house, loving through contest, and never once, in the entire training, scheduling the lesson the type would need for the next fifty years: what to do with the love when nobody will fight you for it.

The Repertoire

The adult repertoire is the apprenticeship, hardened into mastery: the engagement

ABOUT THE AUTHOR

Aiman Sterling is the author of The Archetype Series -- a library of personality portraits drawn the way literature draws characters: the great types of human temperament, recognized at a glance, understood in depth, and followed from childhood wound to mature strength.